fear that it would singe him. His leadership failure as prime minister in those turbulent days would significantly contribute to the eventual demise of the UPA-II government.

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The first intimate meeting I had with Dr Manmohan Singh was on the eve of the 1999 general elections when he was made to contest a Lok Sabha election for the first time, from South Delhi. He had already built an impressive reputation as an economist who as finance minister had delivered the historic 1991 Union budget that had opened up the Indian economy like never before. But here he was being asked to garner votes, a completely different challenge. My assignment at NDTV was to spend a day with Dr Singh on the campaign trail. I was fascinated with the prospect of a middle-class professional academic-bureaucrat who had spent much of his life reading books and files now attempting to transform himself into a mass leader.

We started early in the morning, read a vast bundle of newspapers and went on a walk together. Dr Singh was filing his nomination that day, so he had to climb on a large truck encircled by muscular Sardars and the local Congress workers. His doughty wife Gursharan Kaur kept a safe distance, only ensuring that her ‘Sardarji’ had eaten a good breakfast and the kurta–pyjama was well starched. I remember asking him later in the evening what the most difficult thing was about trying to be an MP. His answer with a mild smile was, ‘Being pushed around by so many people. Everyone, it seems, wants to shake your hand!’

My lasting memory of that day spent with Dr Singh came in our post-lunch shoot. Dr Singh wasn’t the most spontaneous or voluble guest in front of the camera, so we were keenly looking for some ‘colour’ that would lift our programme. We found out that it was the birthday of one of his grandchildren and a small party had been organized on the lawns at the back of the house. Dr Singh, we were told, would spend some time with the children while the cake was being cut. ‘Ideal TV image,’ said my